NAFTA & The Contract with America

1992 & 1994

Source: NAFTA Preamble (1992), Government of Canada; and the Republican Contract with America (Sept. 27, 1994), U.S. House of Representatives. Public domain. Complete texts of the preamble and the Contract.

> Two defining documents of the 1990s: NAFTA created a North American free-trade zone linking the U.S., Canada, and Mexico, while the Contract with America laid out the House Republicans' agenda that swept them to a majority in 1994.

COMPLETE TEXT — UNEDITED

Part 1 — North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA), Preamble (1992)

The Government of Canada, the Government of the United Mexican States and the Government of the United States of America, resolved to: Strengthen the special bonds of friendship and cooperation among their nations; Contribute to the harmonious development and expansion of world trade and provide a catalyst to broader international cooperation; Create an expanded and secure market for the goods and services produced in their territories; Reduce distortions to trade; Establish clear and mutually advantageous rules governing their trade; Ensure a predictable commercial framework for business planning and investment.

Build on their respective rights and obligations under the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade; Enhance the competitiveness of their firms in global markets; Foster creativity and innovation, and promote trade in goods and services that are the subject of intellectual property rights; Create new employment opportunities and improve working conditions and living standards in their respective territories; Undertake each of the preceding in a manner consistent with environmental protection and conservation; Preserve their flexibility to safeguard the public welfare; Promote sustainable development; and Protect, enhance and enforce basic workers' rights; Have agreed as follows.

Part 2 — Contract with America (September 27, 1994)

As Republican Members of the House of Representatives and as citizens seeking to join that body we propose not just to change its policies, but even more important, to restore the bonds of trust between the people and their elected representatives. That is why, in this era of official evasion and posturing, we offer instead a detailed agenda for national renewal, a written commitment with no fine print.

This year's election offers the chance, after four decades of one-party control, to bring to the House a new majority that will transform the way Congress works. That historic change would be the end of government that is too big, too intrusive, and too easy with the public's money. It can be the beginning of a Congress that respects the values and shares the faith of the American family.

On the first day of the 104th Congress, the new Republican majority will immediately pass the following major reforms: FIRST, require all laws that apply to the rest of the country also apply equally to the Congress; SECOND, select a major, independent auditing firm to conduct a comprehensive audit of Congress for waste, fraud or abuse; THIRD, cut the number of House committees, and cut committee staff by one-third; FOURTH, limit the terms of all committee chairs; FIFTH, ban the casting of proxy votes in committee; SIXTH, require committee meetings to be open to the public; SEVENTH, require a three-fifths majority vote to pass a tax increase; EIGHTH, guarantee an honest accounting of our Federal Budget by implementing zero base-line budgeting.

Thereafter, within the first 100 days of the 104th Congress, we shall bring to the House Floor the following bills, each to be given full and open debate, each to be given a clear and fair vote:

THE FISCAL RESPONSIBILITY ACT: A balanced budget/tax limitation amendment and a legislative line-item veto. THE TAKING BACK OUR STREETS ACT: An anti-crime package including stronger truth-in-sentencing, effective death penalty provisions, and funding for prison construction and additional law enforcement. THE PERSONAL RESPONSIBILITY ACT: Discourage illegitimacy and teen pregnancy by prohibiting welfare to minor mothers, cut

spending for welfare programs, and enact a tough two-years-and-out provision with work requirements. THE FAMILY REINFORCEMENT ACT: Child support enforcement, tax incentives for adoption, strengthening rights of parents in their children's education, and stronger child pornography laws.

THE AMERICAN DREAM RESTORATION ACT: A $500 per child tax credit, begin repeal of the marriage tax penalty, and creation of American Dream Savings Accounts. THE NATIONAL SECURITY RESTORATION ACT: No U.S. troops under U.N. command and restoration of the essential parts of our national security funding. THE SENIOR CITIZENS FAIRNESS ACT: Raise the Social Security earnings limit and repeal the 1993 tax hikes on Social Security benefits. THE JOB CREATION AND WAGE ENHANCEMENT ACT: Small business incentives, capital gains cut and indexation, and unfunded mandate reform. THE COMMON SENSE LEGAL REFORM ACT: “Loser pays” laws and reasonable limits on punitive damages. THE CITIZEN LEGISLATURE ACT: A first-ever vote on term limits to replace career politicians with citizen legislators.

Respecting the judgment of our fellow citizens as we seek their mandate for reform, we hereby pledge our names to this Contract with America.